

Case Study Analysis

Title: Media Relations Under Pressure-Qantas

Case study

1. Introduction

The organization which I am going to talk about is the Australia's largest airline——Qantas. According to ABC report published by Nassim Khadem (2023), the airline has been accused of operating “ghost flights,” meaning tickets were sold and payments collected for flights that had already been cancelled. As of August 2023, the issue involved more than 70,000 flights and affected approximately 86,000 passengers, and the Australian Competition and Consumer Commission (ACCC) launched legal action in August 2023. And according to Shaun Temby and John Naoom (2024) this scandal resulting in a A\$120 million settlement and heavy media and regulatory scrutiny. Many members of the public condemned the incident. Also, the media and newspapers criticized Qantas. The Guardian even used phrases such as “egregious conduct” and “betrayal of public trust.”

2. Analysis

The primary target public are [Australian mainstream media](#), as they shape public perception mostly. Secondary target public are stakeholders, like affected customers, whose experiences feed media narratives. The two are linked: customers'

dissatisfaction fuels negative coverage, while media framing pressures Qantas to act. Qantas mainly used one-way communication: press releases, court filings, and public apologies, later adding updates like “Qantas Responds.” While this kept messages consistent for media, limited two-way engagement with customers reduced opportunities to address concerns directly and build trust.

From Karryon (2023) we can know that Qantas chairman Richard Goyder recently issued an apology to customers. In its filing to the Federal Court, Qantas stated that it did not sell “ghost flights” because all paying passengers either received a flight or a refund. In addition, Qantas acknowledged that it had indeed “disappointed customers” during that period and noted that it was the post-pandemic recovery phase, when flight cancellation rates were high and both systems and staffing faced significant challenges.

According to Mahoney (2017), messages must be relevant to target public and expressed in terms they understand. Qantas’ statement addresses the legal core of the accusation, making it relevant to regulatory bodies and investors. However, its public-facing impact is weaker. The phrasing “disappointed customers” is vague and lacks emotional acknowledgement of passenger frustration. This risks a gap between organizational intent and public interpretation, where the message may be legally precise but emotionally insufficient.

Kent (2011) notes that logical fallacies, such as the ‘red herring’, can undermine message credibility. By emphasizing pandemic recovery challenges, Qantas reframes the issue toward uncontrollable external factors, potentially diverting attention from

the central statement, whether the airline sold tickets for flights unlikely to operate. While contextualizing disruptions can be legitimate, over-reliance on such framing risks being perceived as excuse-making. From my personal point of view, as mentioned earlier, Qantas, as the largest airline in Australia, is unlikely to lack the ability to manage risks and make internal adjustments. Moreover, it has been several years since the pandemic began. As a consumer, I feel that this is Qantas making excuses for its own mistakes rather than offering a truly sincere apology. In a media environment where competitive framing is strong and “ghost flights” is an emotive label, audiences are likely to detect and resist perceived deflection.

Qantas’ statement demonstrates partial alignment with message relevance principles but waste empathetic communication. Its reliance on contextual explanations flirts with logical fallacies, potentially weakening its persuasive impact in the court of public opinion. Integrating clear accountability and emotional resonance could strengthen both its legal and reputation positioning.

Moreover, from Rod McGuirk (2024) we know that Qantas CEO Vanessa Hudson stated: “We recognize that during the restart of airline services after COVID, many customers were affected. We failed to provide timely notification of flight cancellations and did not meet our own standards, for which we sincerely apologize.” Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT) views crises as threats to an organization’s reputation, requiring responses that protect reputation capital (Coombs, 2007). In her statement, Hudson directly acknowledged operational failures—delayed notifications and not meeting service standards—and issued a clear apology. This

aligns with SCCT's rebuild strategy, which is recommended when the organization has high responsibility for the crisis. By taking ownership and apologies, Qantas aims to restore trust among stakeholders and counter the negative framing of the "ghost flights" controversy in the media. However, while the admission addresses responsibility, the absence of concrete corrective measures could limit the long-term reputation benefit.

3. Recommendation.

Benoit's Image Repair Theory emphasize the role of mortification (admitting fault and apologizing) in repairing damaged image (Benoit, 2020). Hudson's use of "we sincerely apologize" employs mortification to appeal to public empathy. She also contextualizes the crisis within the COVID-19 restart, which reflects a "reducing offensiveness" strategy, framing the failure as partly due to exceptional background.

This may soften blame for some audiences but risks being seen as partial excuse-making, particularly in competitive media environments where public "open vigilance" is high. To strengthen repair, pairing apology with clear, verifiable commitments (e.g., improved notification systems) would better align with best practices in crisis communication planning (Sellnow & Seeger, 2021).

Qantas showed a mixed but improving performance. The early stance was defensive and technical, but later communications shifted toward apology, restitution and process reform. The AU\$120m settlement and new 24/48-hour rules created credible "proof points" that the media could report clearly.

There are some successful of the feedback of Qantas, for example: Vanessa Hudson's public apology and ongoing "Qantas Responds" updates inform leadership accountability and kept a single source-of-truth for journalists. That aligns with Neill's ethics competencies: transparency, accountability and candour.

Also, there are some drawback of it. Qantas's initial responses underplayed harm and leaned on operational explanations, which invited adversarial framing ("egregious and unacceptable") and extended the news cycle. Delays in notifying customers—sometimes weeks—clashed with dialogic expectations and Neill's call for candour. This gap weakened trust and increased scrutiny. Moreover, the company relied heavily on one-way statements rather than sustained two-way dialogue with affected public, falling short of Kent & Taylor's dialogic model.

Using Kent and Taylor's (2016) dialogic CSR ideas, Qantas can use the "ghost flights" case to rebuild trust. A simple public dashboard, updated daily, could show cancellations and when customers were told, with results checked by an independent audit. Monthly media talks would give reporters a chance to ask questions directly. A small "social care newsroom" could call or message affected customers one-on-one and share basic, anonymous case results with the media. This would change Qantas's approach from one-way statements to open, two-way communication, making progress easy for everyone to see.

From a public relations view, Qantas moved from early defensive statements to later apology and compensation in the "ghost flights" case. Hudson's clear apology showed responsibility and honesty, matching crisis communication best practices. However,

the first responses downplayed harm and gave too many operational excuses, which hurt trust and let negative media framing grow. The AU\$120m settlement and service changes helped improve the image, but to fully rebuild trust, Qantas needs ongoing open communication, regular updates, and direct talks with affected customers.

Critical reflection

In my work for Assessment 1 and 2 on Minus18, a non-profit supporting rural LGBTQ youth, and Assessment 3 on Qantas' "ghost flights" controversy, I saw both similarities and clear differences in how for-profit and non-profit organizations manage media relations.

Both cases highlight the importance of making messages relevant to the audience.

Mahoney (2017) explains that messages must connect to the public's needs and be easy to understand. Minus18 achieved this by framing its campaign to challenge prejudice against rural LGBTQ youth through multiple channels—social media campaigns, press releases, co-produced feature stories with media outlets, and in-person events. Inviting MPs to attend events gave the campaign political weight, while emotional storytelling made the issue relatable and encouraged donations. By focusing on shared values of fairness and inclusion, Minus18 built a positive relationship with journalists and reached a broad audience.

Qantas faced a very different context. In the "ghost flights" case, the airline was accused by outlets such as The Guardian and ABC News of selling tickets for flights later cancelled. According to Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT), when an organization is seen as responsible for a crisis, it needs to rebuild trust by accepting responsibility and showing concern (Coombs, 2007). Qantas CEO Vanessa Hudson apologized, admitted the company failed to provide timely cancellation notices, and explained operational challenges after COVID-19. This followed SCCT's "rebuild" strategy, aiming to protect reputation by directly addressing the issue.

The main difference lies in approach. Minus18's work was proactive, advocacy-driven, and aimed at inspiring change, while Qantas' was reactive, focused on limiting damage. Minus18's transparency and inclusivity aligned with public interest, whereas Qantas' framing risked being seen as excuse-making, despite offering an apology.

In the future, for-profits like Qantas could integrate Minus18's authenticity and audience-focused storytelling to strengthen trust in crisis responses. Non-profits could adopt structured communication plans, as seen in corporate crisis management, to protect their reputations during potential controversies. For both, success depends on timely, relevant, and honest communication.

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